The Olympic Games

Introduction to the Olympic Games

The Olympic Games are the world's largest international multi-sport event, in which thousands of athletes from over 200 nations compete in summer and winter sports. They are held every four years, with the Summer Games and the Winter Games alternating every two years. The Games are organised by the International Olympic Committee (IOC), based in Lausanne, Switzerland. The Olympic ideals are excellence, friendship and respect, and the Olympic motto is "Citius, Altius, Fortius", Latin for "Faster, Higher, Stronger", to which the word "Communiter" meaning "Together" was added in 2021.

Ancient Olympics

The ancient Olympic Games were held at Olympia in Greece, in honour of Zeus, beginning in 776 BCE according to tradition, and were held every four years for almost 1,200 years until they were banned by the Roman emperor Theodosius I in about 393 CE. Only free Greek men took part, and the winners got olive wreaths. A sacred truce was observed during the Games.

When Were the First Modern Olympics Held?

The first modern Olympic Games were held in 1896 in Athens, Greece, from 6 to 15 April 1896. They were revived by the French educator and sports enthusiast Baron Pierre de Coubertin, who founded the International Olympic Committee on 23 June 1894 at the Sorbonne in Paris, and is called the father of the modern Olympics. The 1896 Games had 14 nations and about 241 athletes, all men, who competed in nine sports, with the marathon, inspired by the legend of Pheidippides, and the winner of the first marathon was the Greek Spyridon Louis. Women first took part in 1900 in Paris, when Charlotte Cooper of Britain became the first female Olympic champion in tennis. The Winter Olympics began in 1924 at Chamonix, France, and the Paralympic Games started in 1960 in Rome. Recent Games include Tokyo 2020 (held in 2021 because of COVID-19), Paris 2024, with Los Angeles in 2028 and Brisbane in 2032.

What Do the Five Rings Stand For?

The Olympic symbol of five interlocking rings represents the union of the five inhabited continents of the world, Africa, the Americas, Asia, Europe and Oceania, and the meeting of athletes from all over the world at the Games. The rings are blue, yellow, black, green and red, set on a white background, and the six colours (including white) were chosen so that every national flag in the world at that time would include at least one of them. The symbol was designed by Pierre de Coubertin in 1913 and first flown at the 1920 Antwerp Games. It is not true that each ring represents a particular continent, since Coubertin did not assign colours to continents. The Olympic flame, lit at Olympia using the rays of the sun with a parabolic mirror, is taken by torch relay to the host city, a tradition started at the 1936 Berlin Games, and burns during the Games.

Olympic Traditions

The opening ceremony includes the parade of nations, led by Greece, with the host nation last, and the athletes' oath. Gold, silver and bronze medals are awarded to the first three, and the national anthem of the winner is played. Paris 2024 had 32 sports, with new events such as breaking, and the medals incorporated pieces of the Eiffel Tower's original iron.

India at the Olympics

India first sent a single athlete, Norman Pritchard, to the 1900 Paris Games, where he won two silver medals in athletics, and sent its first team in 1920. The Indian men's hockey team dominated the early Games, winning gold at Amsterdam in 1928, the first of eight Olympic gold medals, with a streak of six consecutive golds from 1928 to 1956 featuring the legend Major Dhyan Chand, and later gold in 1964 and 1980. K. D. Jadhav won India's first individual medal after independence, a bronze in wrestling, at Helsinki in 1952. Leander Paes won bronze in tennis in 1996, and Karnam Malleswari became the first Indian woman to win an Olympic medal, a bronze in weightlifting in 2000.

Who Won India's First Individual Olympic Gold?

India's first individual Olympic gold medal was won by Abhinav Bindra in the men's 10 metre air rifle event at the Beijing Olympics in 2008, on 11 August 2008. He scored 700.5 points, which made him the first Indian to win an individual gold medal at the Olympics. Earlier gold medals were all won by the hockey team. Neeraj Chopra won India's second individual Olympic gold and the first gold in athletics at the Tokyo Olympics, held in 2021, in the men's javelin throw, on 7 August 2021, with a throw of 87.58 metres, and he followed it with a silver at Paris 2024. India's other medallists include Sushil Kumar, who won two medals, Vijay Kumar, Saina Nehwal, Mary Kom, P. V. Sindhu, who won silver in 2016 and bronze in 2020 as India's first woman to win two individual Olympic medals, Mirabai Chanu, who won silver in weightlifting in Tokyo, and Manu Bhaker, who won two bronze medals in shooting at Paris 2024. By the end of Paris 2024, India had won 41 Olympic medals in total, including 10 gold medals.

The Olympic Movement and the Paralympics

The Paralympic Games are held for athletes with disabilities, following the Olympics. India won 29 medals at the Paris 2024 Paralympics, its best, and Tamil Nadu's Mariyappan Thangavelu, from Salem, who won high jump medals in 2016 and 2020, is one of India's Paralympic stars. The Youth Olympic Games and the Commonwealth Games are other multi-sport events. India has expressed interest in hosting the Olympic Games in the future, and Ahmedabad was selected to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games.

Challenges and Future

Challenges of the Olympics include the high cost of hosting, doping, political controversies and inclusion of new sports. Efforts such as the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) and the Khelo India programme aim to improve India's performance.

Quick Facts

- The first modern Olympics were held in 1896 in Athens, Greece, revived by Pierre de Coubertin.
- The five rings stand for the five inhabited continents united by the Olympic movement.
- Abhinav Bindra won India's first individual Olympic gold in 10 m air rifle at Beijing 2008.
- Neeraj Chopra won gold in javelin at Tokyo 2020 (held in 2021).
- Olympic motto: Citius, Altius, Fortius, Communiter.